

One Federal: Good, not great: ARCHITECTURE

Campbell, Robert
Boston Globe (1960-); Aug 15, 1976; ProQuest
pg. C10

Before you blame the architect, remember that when the city permitted Shawmut to build 50 percent more bulk on the site than zoning would have allowed, it was guaranteeing that the building would look too big no matter how it was designed.

One Federal: Good, not great

After 40 years, the Chrysler Building and the Empire State Building are still prestigious, despite the fact that their ground floors are full of sandwich shops and haberdashers.

So why is it that every new office tower in Boston seems to feel that the only way to get dignity and "image" is to confront the sidewalk with a blank, empty ego trip?

Executive suites in the clouds are fine, but as far as a pedestrian is concerned any building is only about three stories high. If the ground floors deaden, instead of brighten, your experience of the city, the building's a loss.

The latest example of these problems is the new Shawmut National Bank Building, also known as One Federal Street. Shawmut, let it be said quickly, is a big improvement over the typical office tower. But it still raises the old questions.

In a way, it's a case of a sensitive and hardworking architect fighting a losing battle against forces he had little to do with creating. The Shawmut bank had the good sense to hire the Architects Collaborative, but unfortunately did so only after the big decisions about the building had already been made.

Within those limits, TAC did well. There's no doubt, for instance, that the building works for the owner and staff. Office layouts are well planned, elevators a swift

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

dream, the cafeteria sunny. Of all the interiors, only a slightly grim entrance lobby and a vast, Palace-of-the-Tsars executive floor seem a little strained.

The questions come, as usual, at the seam where the building meets the public — a public, let's remember, that has helped pay for the building through tax concessions, zoning variances and public services.

To most members of that public, Shawmut seems hulkingly large on its site and cavernous in the face it turns to the street.

But before you blame the architect, remember that when the city permitted Shawmut to build 50 percent more bulk on the site than zoning would have allowed, it was guaranteeing that the building would look too big no matter how it was designed.

Here, as elsewhere, a "Planned Development Area" circumvented Boston's admittedly archaic zoning and let Shawmut build the bulk it thought was most economically sound.

As for the cavernous monumental street frontage, that was the owner's choice though one suspects TAC had some fun with it. It was 1969 when Shawmut was planned, and that was the year Harvard Trust bricked up its front in fear of stone-

throwing radicals. Shawmut certainly wasn't interested in a lot of glass shopfronts. Besides the danger, they would have diluted the bank's "image."

So the all-important street level consists of little besides a far too spacious and empty lobby, the inevitable Shawmut branch bank, and a lot of dark open space carved out from beneath the building. This space, the architects tell us with chutzpah, will "allow passersby as well as users to experience (the building's) form as a piece of sculpture."

The irony in all this comes through best in the rental ads — some 27 of the Shawmut's 38 floors are being rented out. "The five-minute building," blurbs the ad. "No kidding ... no more than five minutes away from any place in downtown Boston. Oh sure: you could prove us wrong by dawdling and stopping to look in store windows, but otherwise we think it's a pretty fair estimate."

The irony is that no one can dawdle over any store windows at the Shawmut itself. It has a few, but they're trivial in comparison to the four blocks of Boston streetscape the building occupies. Proud to be close to everything else Shawmut sees no need to add any commercial street life or

services that others might like to be near.

You don't have to quarrel with the idea that it's good to keep businesses like Shawmut downtown in order to quarrel with both its bulk and its lack of street life.

All those problems were already built into the problem TAC was asked to solve, and they have more to do with corporate enlightenment and the city's urban design policy than they do with architecture.

The architecture itself is pretty good. First of all, it recognizes the basic fact that Boston is a city of winding streets and of funny-shaped blocks where every building site is unique. Boston is the opposite of New York's uniform midtown grid, in which building can be interchangeable cubes. Ignoring that distinction means giving Boston a New York-style tower like One Beacon street, which is like a forge-hammer on a curving street on the edge of delicate Beacon Hill. The Shawmut, instead, adjusts to its site, taking the shape of a trapezoid because that's the shape of the block, leaving no windy left-over plazas. It firmly continues the street-walls and even something of the mass and color of nearby granite.

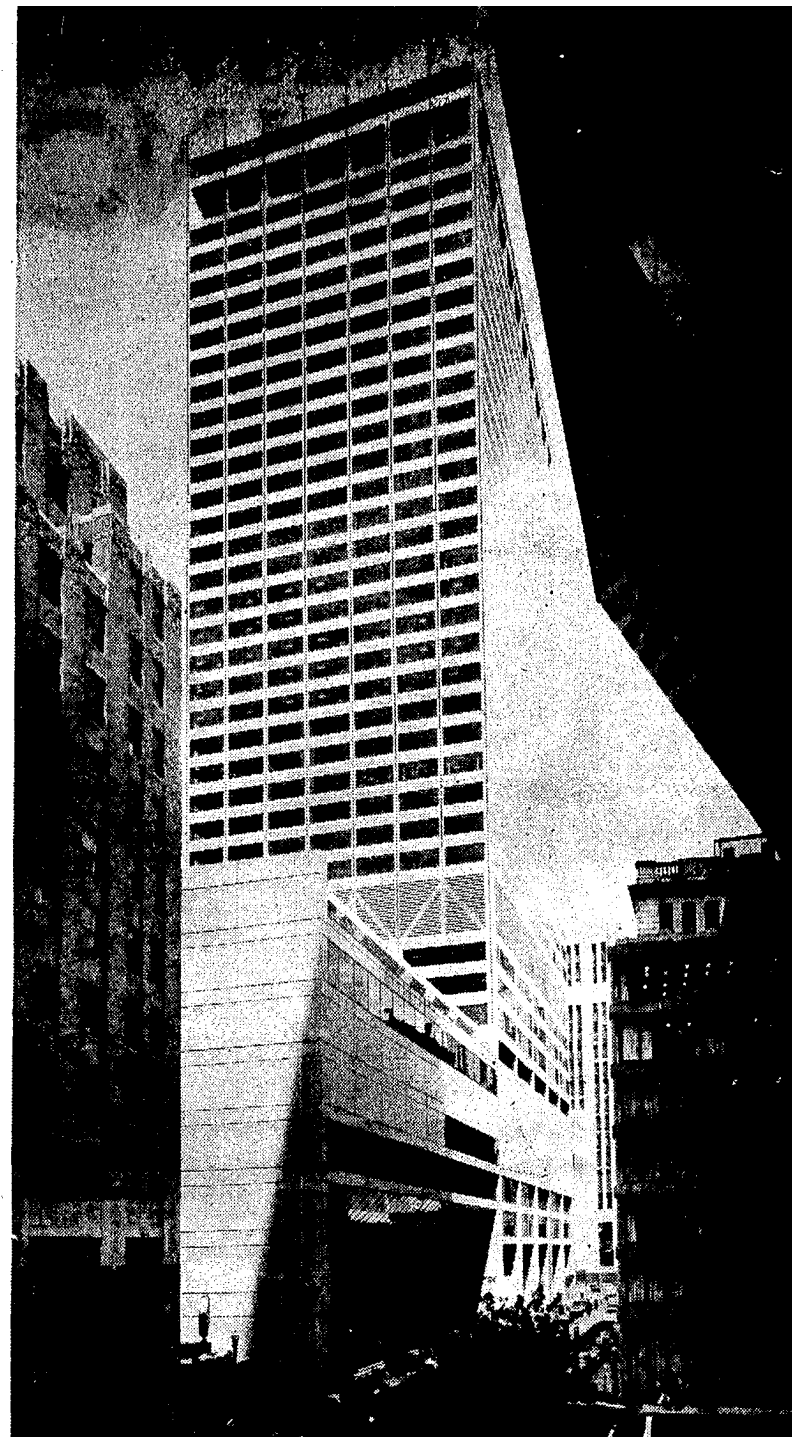
TAC's solution works well at the top, too, a magic place in a skyscraper. Far better than handing this special space over to the

bigshots, Shawmut instead puts the brass down on the 11th floor, leaving the top free for a more public use. They failed to attract a restaurant and so leased to the Harvard Club, which is filling the huge windows with lunch tables. Not a populist tenant, but an appropriate one. From outside, the deep-set windows top off the tower successfully.

Viewed as an object, without regard for use or context, Shawmut is ambiguous and intriguing. Like other nearby banks — State Street, First National — it has a fat bottom and slim tower, the fat bottom being the huge "operations floors" the banks say they need.

Because TAC wanted to hold the street edge as strongly as it could, both tower and bottom are pulled into a single vertical plane, making the whole building a kind of cross shape with the tower looking like a tall coal trolley sliding along a track. It's a complex, ambiguous relationship, more interesting than most.

Ambitious, raising many issues about the relationship of these towers to one's experience of the city, the Shawmut Bank Building is the best downtown tower since Edward Larrabee Barnes' New England Merchants building. But it also reminds us that no architect can make urban delight out of a ponderous, self-involved building program. It takes a public-minded client and city as well.



National Shawmut Bank Building at One Federal